

CDS Examination Documentation

1. CDS Exam Format

The **Combined Defence Services (CDS) Examination** is conducted by the **Union Public Service Commission (UPSC)** twice every year as **CDS (I)** and **CDS (II)**. The written examination is conducted offline and consists of objective-type papers.

Academy	Papers/Subjects	Duration	Written Marks
IMA – Indian Military Academy	English, General Knowledge, Elementary Mathematics	2 hours each	300
INA – Indian Naval Academy	English, General Knowledge, Elementary Mathematics	2 hours each	300
AFA – Air Force Academy	English, General Knowledge, Elementary Mathematics	2 hours each	300
OTA – Officers' Training Academy	English, General Knowledge	2 hours each	200

The official UPSC notification specifies **100 marks per paper**. Therefore, IMA/INA/AFA candidates take **3 papers**, while OTA candidates take **2 papers**.

2. Number of Stages in Selection

The CDS selection process can be summarized into **two major stages**:

Stage 1 – Written Examination

Candidates first appear for the UPSC CDS written examination.

Stage 2 – SSB Interview

Candidates who qualify the written examination are called for the **Services Selection Board (SSB)** process, which assesses intelligence, personality, leadership qualities and officer potential.

After SSB, candidates must also satisfy the applicable **medical/physical requirements**, and final selection is based on merit, eligibility, vacancies and medical fitness.

Overall flow:

UPSC Written Exam → SSB Interview/Assessment → Medical Examination → Final Merit/Selection → Academy Training

3. How Many CDS Examinations Have Been Conducted Historically?

UPSC conducts **two CDS examinations per year**:

- **CDS (I)**
- **CDS (II)**

This pattern has been followed for many years; UPSC records from the 2010s and later explicitly show separate CDS (I) and CDS (II) examinations.

For example:

- 2024 → CDS I & CDS II
- 2025 → CDS I & CDS II
- 2026 → CDS I & CDS II

UPSC's examination archive confirms **CDS I 2026** was conducted on **12 April 2026**, while **CDS II 2026** is scheduled for **13 September 2026**.

Therefore, the examination is normally conducted at a rate of approximately **2 examination cycles per year**. The exact historical total depends on the starting year and any exceptional years in which an examination was not held, so it is better not to state a single lifetime number without defining the historical period.

4. How Many Question Papers?

For every CDS examination cycle:

- **IMA/INA/AFA:** 3 question papers
 - English
 - General Knowledge
 - Elementary Mathematics
- **OTA:** 2 question papers
 - English
 - General Knowledge

Thus, **5 distinct paper types are associated with each CDS examination cycle**, although the English and GK papers are common across the academy entries. UPSC's previous-question-paper repository publishes these papers separately.

For example, the UPSC archive contains the **CDS I 2026 English, General Knowledge and Elementary Mathematics papers** and previous CDS papers from earlier years.

5. Sources Used for CDS Papers

The **primary and most reliable source for historical CDS question papers is the official UPSC Previous Question Papers repository**.

Primary Source

UPSC – Previous Year Question Papers

[UPSC Previous Question Papers](#)

The repository provides official CDS papers, including **English, General Knowledge and Elementary Mathematics**, with historical archives available for earlier examination years.

Official Examination Notifications

UPSC's examination notifications provide the authoritative information on:

- Examination scheme
- Subjects
- Duration
- Marks
- Syllabus
- Selection procedure

[UPSC Examination Notifications Archive](#)

Historical/Supporting Sources

For historical analysis, additional supporting material can be obtained from:

- UPSC Annual Reports
- UPSC Final Results Archives
- Official UPSC examination archives

The UPSC Annual Reports document the recurring CDS I/CDS II examination cycles, while the final-result archive provides historical evidence of conducted examinations.

Summary

Item	Details
Conducting body	UPSC
Frequency	2 times per year
Exams	CDS I and CDS II
IMA papers	3
INA papers	3
AFA papers	3
OTA papers	2
Subjects	English, General Knowledge, Elementary Mathematics
Written exam	Objective type, offline
Selection stages	Written Exam → SSB → Medical → Final Merit

Primary paper source	Official UPSC Previous Question Papers
Official pattern source	UPSC CDS Examination Notification
Historical evidence	UPSC examination archives and Annual Reports